

experienced international football through television suddenly found their teams appearing a short drive away.

A Brazilian home match could emerge in New Jersey. Argentina could turn Atlanta or Dallas into Buenos Aires for an evening. The Haitians could revel in defeat, while the African diaspora celebrated the march of the continent's nations into the knockout rounds.

America did not simply host the world. Much of the world was already living within it.

That was why the atmosphere felt different from the carefully imported FIFA spectacle. The passion did not have to be manufactured. It existed in Queens and New Jersey, in South Florida's Latin American communities, among West Africans in the Washington corridor and South Asians who followed Argentina from one end of the country to the other.

They filled the spaces between the matches. They turned hotel breakfasts into fan gatherings, railway platforms into debates and city streets into improvised parades. The World Cup became visible even to Americans who had no ticket and little previous relationship with the sport.

And the football rewarded them.

Nordic tide: Norway fans performing the "Viking Row" in Miami Beach ahead of their side's quarterfinal against England. GETTY IMAGES

The expanded tournament raised concerns about excess, but it also allowed unfamiliar stories to develop alongside the established powers. Cape Verde supplied one of its most romantic journeys. Norway and Erling Haaland eliminated Brazil. Egypt reached the knockout rounds and pushed Argentina to the edge. By the semifinals, the old hierarchy had returned through Spain, Argentina, France and England, but the road to the last four had been crowded with resistance.

The leading players who arrived with reputations largely lived up to them. Messi extended his World Cup appearance record to 34 matches and, at 39 years and 25 days, became the oldest outfield player to feature in a final. Kylian Mbappe, Haaland, Harry Kane and Jude Bellingham contributed goals and moments worthy of the stage. Rodri controlled the tournament's decisive matches and was rightly named its finest player, not overshadowed by the glamorous goalscorers who tend to hog football's attention.

Spain's teenagers offered a glimpse of what might come next. Lamine Yamal and Pau Cubarsí became only the fourth and fifth teenagers to appear in a men's World Cup final, joining Pele, Giuseppe Bergomi and Mbappe in the exclusive group to do so and finish as champions. Their eight appearances were also the most played at a World Cup before turning 20. The tournament became a meeting point between football's

past and future. Messi pursued one last title while Yamal began building a legacy of his own.

There was entertainment almost everywhere. The 308 goals surpassed the previous tournament record of 172, while the average of 2.96 per game was the highest since the 1970 World Cup in Mexico. Long-range shooting returned as a significant weapon, while late goals repeatedly transformed knockout matches.

Arsène Wenger, FIFA's chief of global football development, believed the tournament would be remembered for its physical intensity, increased competitive balance and the performances of its biggest stars. Gianni Infantino went considerably further, declaring that the World Cup had not merely broken records but "smashed" and "destroyed" them.

FIFA rarely misses an opportunity to proclaim its own success.

But this was not a flawless tournament.

There were moments when football's American takeover began to resemble football being taken over by America.

Matches were divided by mandatory three-minute hydration breaks, even in air-conditioned or closed-roof stadiums, creating pauses conveniently suited to television advertising. The final received a Super Bowl-style extended halftime show. Commercial messaging seemed to occupy almost every unclaimed

